

TOXIC LEAK IN O.C. PROMPTS THOUSANDS TO FLEE

Chemical tank at aerospace firm is expected to fail or explode, officials say.

By Salvador Hernandez,
Clara Harter,
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and Rong-Gong Lin II

A leaking chemical tank at an aerospace firm is going to fail or explode in an “unprecedented” event that saw officials order thousands of Orange County residents to evacuate parts of six cities until it happens, authorities announced Friday afternoon.

“At that point, we know the tank is going into thermal runaway,” Orange County Fire Authority Division Chief Craig Covey said during a news conference Friday. “And we’re going to pull everybody out of the area, make sure it’s safe and let the tank do what it’s going to do.”

The fire authority’s hazardous materials response team began dousing the tanks at a Garden Grove facility Thursday, prompting an initial evacuation order that was lifted later that day. But on Friday morning, officials said a faulty valve and the inability to remove and neutralize the toxic chemical inside the tank had escalated the incident and left them certain that the large tank would, at some point, either fail, leaking thousands of gallons, or explode.

“People need to get out of their houses and get into a safe space,” Covey said.

Evacuations around the failing tank in Garden Grove expanded to include tens of thousands of residents in six Orange County cities: Garden Grove, Cypress, Stanton, Anaheim, Buena Park and Westminster.

The tank, holding about 6,000 to 7,000 gallons of highly toxic methyl methacrylate, or MMA, was described as being “in crisis” Friday.

“There are literally two options left remaining,” Covey said. “The tank fails and spills a total of about [6,000] to 7,000 gallons of very bad chemicals into the parking lot in that area. Or, two, the tank goes into a thermal runaway and blows up, affecting the tanks around them that have fuel or chemicals in them as well.”

That’s the best-case scenario, because once it leaks, it’s no longer at risk of exploding. From there, teams in hazardous material suits can go in and “neutralize and mitigate the vapors that will be coming off of that,” he said.

The worst-case scenario is an uncontrolled explosion, something so big that it would be something like “if you ever seen videos of tank cars on a railroad track blowing up, and that fireball it puts out, and it blows half the tank car half a mile down the train track, that’s the incident potential we are dealing with.”

[See Leak, A12]



Photographs by ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times



WATER is sprayed on a tank at GKN Aerospace in Garden Grove containing methyl methacrylate. Above, Leticia Rinker of Stanton evacuated with her pets.

A frantic two hours before attack on mosque

Mother told San Diego police her son had taken guns. Short-staffed force took 88 minutes to respond.

By Salvador Hernandez and Hannah Fry

SAN DIEGO — The two hours before Monday’s deadly attack at the Islamic Center of San Diego were marked by a series of frantic calls by the mother of one of the attackers as short-staffed police struggled to assess the seriousness of the threat and scramble officers to find the shooters.

The mother of 17-year-old Cain Lee Clark first called police at 9:42 a.m., about two hours before the first reports of an active shooter at the mosque. Police did not

arrive at her home to speak to her until 11:10 a.m., according to sources with access to call logs.

During that time, the mother had called at least two more times, with greater levels of concern, the sources said. Those calls were enough for police to elevate the incident, more than an hour after the initial call.

It’s unclear exactly what the mother told police during the first call, but police officials have said it came in as a “runaway juvenile” and

was classified as a “Priority 2,” one of the two law enforcement sources said.

Multiple law enforcement officials said the waiting time between the mother’s first call and when an officer was dispatched was on par with similarly classified calls.

According to data recently released by the city in a public records request, the average response time for the department for a Priority 2 was more than two hours.

[See Police, A7]

A warm winter deprives SoCal of its cherry harvest this year

By Ian James

On weekends in May, the cars usually spill out of the dirt parking lot at Villa del Sol Sweet Cherry Farms and along both sides of the two-lane road. Yes, they grow cherries in Southern California — in Leona Valley, in the high desert west of Palmdale. For a few weeks, hundreds of families flock there during the U-pick season.

Not this year.

“Sad news,” orchard owner Gary Shafer said on an outgoing voicemail he left for would-be pickers. “We had such a warm winter this last year that we did not get a cherry crop this year. It’s the first time in 23 years.”

In Los Angeles County, average temperatures in the six months from October through March were 4 degrees warmer than the 30-year average, and the warm-

est on record in 131 years. The winter brought unprecedented warmth across the western United States.

Research shows climate change is bringing warmer and shorter winters.

Shafer noticed he could wear a T-shirt while pruning trees instead of the usual hooded sweatshirt and knitted hat. Among the trees, he saw poppies and other wildflowers bloom extremely early.

[See Cherries, A9]

Backlash tests Trump’s grip on lawmakers

Break could spell an end to Republican senators’ compliance with his agenda.

By Ana Ceballos

WASHINGTON — For much of Donald Trump’s second term, Republican senators have largely stayed in line, wary of defying a president with a history of targeting those who cross him. This week, that dynamic noticeably shifted.

Senate Republicans blocked two of Trump’s legislative priorities, angered by the push to create a \$18-billion federal fund to compensate people who claim to have been politically persecuted, including rioters who assaulted the U.S. Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021. The revolt forced Republican leaders to pull a planned vote on legislation to fund the president’s immigration crackdown and security features for his White House ballroom project.

In response, the president defended the fund and lashed out at its critics.

“I gave up a lot of money in allowing the just announced Anti-Weaponization Fund to go forward,” Trump wrote in a post on his social media website. “Instead, I am helping others,

who were so badly abused by an evil, corrupt and weaponized Biden Administration, receive, at long last, JUSTICE!”

The president also called Republican senators who broke with him quitters who are “screwing the Republican Party.”

The friction, which has been building for weeks, is being watched as a potential test of the limits to Trump’s grip on his party amid an already tense political environment heading into the midterm elections.

“This is kind of a perfect storm,” former Sen. Jeff Flake (R-Ariz.) said on NBC’s “Meet the Press.” “It may be that this time you can point to it and say this is when the great migration begins, away from some of the president’s policies and away from the fear that the president can target you.”

Whether this week marks the beginning of that moment — or simply another episode of political turbulence that fades — is the central question now hanging over Trump’s second term.

Not the first break — but an escalation

This is not the first time Republicans have broken with the president. In November, Congress overwhelmingly voted to force [See Revolt, A6]

EPA tests belie fire cleanup claim

It calls Eaton removal a success based on federal lead standard, not state threshold.

By Tony Briscoe

Despite finding nearly 1 in 5 homes had excessive levels of lead, the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency this week claimed that recent soil testing in Altadena proved that expedited federal cleanup efforts had effectively removed toxic ash and debris from homes destroyed by the deadly Eaton fire.

Earlier this year, the EPA announced it would perform a limited soil sampling at 100 destroyed homes across the burn zone in order to verify that contractors had thoroughly mitigated toxic substances. In a recent news release, the EPA said that test-

ing revealed median lead concentrations below federal standards and “confirmed that cleanup methods successfully addressed contamination and verified cleanup protocols.”

The EPA soil sampling comes amid mounting pressure from residents and environmentalists who say that a hasty federal cleanup effort had left behind or spread hazardous fire debris. Internal government reports also raised questions about the thoroughness of the cleanup.

The EPA did not release its report to the public, but it said 95 of 100 soil samples collected near the surface of the homes’ building footprints were below the federal lead screening level.

“I think for the folks in Altadena who maybe had some concerns about the adequacy of the work that was performed by the federal

[See Eaton fire, A9]

At this event, athletes are juiced by design

The Enhanced Games allow the forbidden. Detractors say it’s unethical, dangerous.

By Steve Henson

Last summer, the Enhanced Games were a dubious curiosity, a Peter Thiel fever dream boldly touted as “redefining superhumanity” through the use of steroids, human growth hormone and any other forbidden substances that could improve performance.

On Sunday, the games will become a reality, with 42



DOMENICO CIPPITELLI NurPhoto

SPRINTER Shania Collins is among the elite female athletes who will participate in the Enhanced Games.

mostly juiced athletes attempting to break records in the 100-meter sprint, swimming and weightlifting competitions at Resorts World Las Vegas.

Funded by investors including Thiel, the billionaire founder of PayPal, the games will be lucrative for the athletes, with a total purse of \$25 million and bonuses of \$1 million for anyone who sets a world record.

Enhanced made public Wednesday the drug-use rates of 36 of the athletes scheduled to compete, announcing that its clinical study is listed on Clinicaltrials.gov. Two of the [See Games, A7]



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‘A FIERCE COMPETITOR’

Kyle Busch, who died Thursday at 41, was much more than just a NASCAR villain. He is also remembered as a loving family man. **SPORTS, B12**

Gabbard quits as intelligence chief

Former lawmaker from Hawaii found herself at odds with President Trump over the U.S. war in Iran. **NATION, A5**

Weather

Clouds, then sun. L.A. Basin: 73/58. **B8**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

L.A. Unified to cut 1,000 staffers

Board of Education approves layoffs, and more reductions are planned. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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